Inquiry-Relative Categories: English Interjections as a Worked Case

Brett Reynolds *
Humber Polytechnic & University of Toronto

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Abstract

Linguistic category disputes often combine different questions about the same expressions. I develop an account of inquiry-relative categories, using English interjections as a worked case. The account distinguishes useful descriptive classes from empirical categories whose co-occurring properties support induction for particular purposes. Expressive *Damn!* and depictive *Bang!* show why one inquiry into meaning can require several distinctions: conveying a stance and portraying a sound preserve different relations, despite similarities in grammatical distribution. Phonological resemblance likewise leaves grammatical membership unresolved. These comparisons locate the dispute in the inference being claimed: evidence can support a descriptive distinction without establishing category standing, and failure of one projection leaves independently supported distinctions intact. Several categories can serve one inquiry, just as one category can serve several inquiries. Their legitimacy depends on the inferences they support, making pluralism compatible with empirical grounds for rejecting particular proposals.

Keywords: inquiry-relative categories; category pluralism; projectibility; interjections; sign-types; path dependence

AI use. The large language models Claude Opus 4.8, Claude Opus 5, Claude Opus 5.5, GPT-5.6 Sol, GPT-6 Astra Pro, and GPT-6 (Codex) served as drafting and editing aids throughout the preparation of this paper. I am responsible for all theoretical claims, arguments, errors, and interpretive choices.

1 Introduction

Standalone *Damn!*, complement-taking *Damn these mosquitoes!*, and prenominal *damn* in *the damn car* present different combinations of grammatical and semantic properties. The modifier participates in a noun phrase while retaining an expressive contribution. The standalone form can constitute a stance display. The complement-taking expression has internal structure even when the whole

*Contact: brett.reynolds@humber.ca

expression stands apart from a surrounding clause. A single judgment about whether *damn* is an interjection leaves these differences unresolved.

A comparison with depictive *Bang!* exposes a further distinction. The selected *damn* use conveys an evaluative stance; the selected *Bang!* depicts a sound. Both concern meaning, but they motivate different groupings and different questions about interpretation. Grouping one under semantics and the other under semiotics would do nothing to resolve those questions. Nor would calling both interjections establish that they share the relevant semantic properties.

This paper asks what warrants recognizing a category for an inquiry. An inquiry identifies a question and a standard of success; evidence constrains which grouping answers it. A field can pursue several inquiries, an inquiry can employ several categories, and a category can serve questions pursued across fields. English interjections make this many-to-many relation visible because grammatical, semantic, interactional, phonological, and historical descriptions repeatedly organize overlapping material.

A grouping can make measurement comparable or description informative. The distinctions among *damn* uses have descriptive value even before a new prediction is tested. Projectibility concerns the warrant for expectations beyond the evidence used to identify a case (Goodman, 1955). Neither descriptive usefulness nor a successful projection identifies its own causal explanation. These achievements need separate assessment.

Pluralism about useful and objectively grounded groupings has substantial precedents. Dupré (1993, pp. 5–7, 17–18) relates the choice of classification to the goals of inquiry while rejecting one uniquely privileged division of things. Khalidi (2013, pp. 63–64, 69–72) defends crosscutting kinds answering different epistemic interests. Their wider metaphysical commitments needn't all be adopted to recognize that distinct questions can require overlapping groupings.

Within linguistics, Haspelmath (2010, pp. 663, 666, 680) distinguishes language-particular descriptive categories from concepts designed for cross-language comparison. The division of labour here is different: several inquiries within English can organize the same expressions differently. The assessment developed here identifies where evidence for one claim leaves another unsupported. A semantic contrast can be preserved without establishing category-wide projections; phonological resemblance can leave grammatical membership unresolved. Specifying the bearer, grouping, and intended inference makes those transitions available for adjudication.

The worked cases are named for the relations they investigate: grammatical interjections, expressive signs, depictive signs, continuers, repair initiators, and closing formats. They needn't all operate at the same level of generality or retain an interjection label. In these comparisons, the common bearer is a conventionalized sign-type, an identifiable expression in a conventional use. Classifications of realizations or historical changes require explicit relations to these sign-types.

The historical case concerns path dependence: development can leave source-specific traces after uses converge. Gehweiler's history of *gee* supplies a documented explanation of one outcome; a verbal route to complement-taking *damn* remains partly reconstructive. The corpus material has a narrower role, showing how tags and strings can fail to identify the intended bearers. A linked supplement preserves the detailed measurement checks and two withdrawn confirmatory analyses.

Section 2 develops the named groupings and completes an expressive–depictive comparison. Section 3 distinguishes their possible achievements. Sections 4 and 5 apply the assessment to phonological and historical claims; Section 6 considers broader social and processing classes. The measure-

ment case and discussion then draw out what changes when the object, grouping, and claim are kept explicit.

2 Several groupings of conventional signs

Grammars and studies of meaning and interaction organize the traditional interjection domain differently. Jespersen (1924, p. 90) treated interjection as a manner in which words of other categories are used. *The Cambridge Grammar of the English Language* (*CGEL*) recognizes a lexical category (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 22). The *Longman Grammar of Spoken and Written English* places interjections within the broader class of inserts, while assigning *damn*, *gosh*, and *gee* to expletives (Biber et al., 1999, pp. 1082–1083, 1094–1095).

The disputes concern a well-studied domain. Libert (2019) questions the description of interjections as neglected; Cram (2008, p. 63) identifies their recurring role in controversies over the syntax–pragmatics and semantics–pragmatics boundaries. The following comparisons preserve what those traditions distinguish without treating each tradition as the source of exactly one category.

2.1 Grammatical interjections and expressive signs

The grammatical proposal begins with standalone and supplement distribution. In *Damn, we're going to be late!*, *damn* is appended to the clause without being its complement or modifier. *CGEL* treats interjections as occurring on their own or functioning as supplements (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 1350, 1361). In those conventional uses, they're characteristically invariant and resist the ordinary constituent positions available to nouns, verbs, or adjectives.

Supplement function is shared by several categories. Compare the interjection with the relative clause and noun phrase in these examples, adapted from *CGEL* (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 1356–1357, 1360).

(1) a. *Ah, so you were there after all!*
b. *We called in to see Sue's parents, which made us rather late.*
c. *A university lecturer, Dr Brown, was arrested for the crime.*

Their external relation to a host leaves their internal grammatical differences intact. The same applies to *Damn these mosquitoes!*: the whole phrase's detachment is compatible with complementation inside it. *CGEL* tentatively treats the head as an exceptional interjection taking a noun-phrase complement (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, 1361 n. 70). A verbal analysis remains a substantive alternative. Neither the complement nor the whole phrase's independence decides between them alone.

Prenominal *damn*, in *the damn car*, occurs inside the noun phrase while contributing an attitude toward its referent. Potts (2007, pp. 171, 182) distinguishes that expressive contribution from descriptive content. Grammatical integration leaves a semantic relation to standalone *Damn!* available for analysis. A single degree of interjectionhood would conceal which respect is shared and which differs.

The semantic grouping here is expressive signs: conventional uses whose deployment conveys an evaluative or affective stance, rather than merely describing that stance. This intended contribution is narrower than all non-descriptive or use-conditional meaning. A conventional instruction for managing interpretation or interaction needn't express such a stance. Potts's diagnostics include perspective dependence, immediacy, and intensifying repetition (Potts, 2007, pp. 166–167). For *damn*,

these ask whose attitude is conveyed, whether the utterance displays that attitude on the occasion of speaking, and whether repeating the form strengthens it. Whether those properties travel together across the proposed extension is an empirical question.

The grouping is broader than grammatical interjections. The examples in this paper are a selected part of it, chosen from disputes about interjections; that selection supplies no additional semantic membership condition. A broader account of expressives can include integrated signs with no traditional interjection label. Its descriptive benefit here is to preserve the expressive–descriptive distinction across independently identified grammatical constructions.

2.2 Expressive and depictive signs

Compare the selected expressive use of *Damn!* with a sound depiction *Bang!* in a narrative. The bearer in each case is the conventional use, not every occurrence of the spelling. The question is what contribution the use makes to interpretation. The strongest simple alternative groups both as expressive interjections on the basis of their vividness and standalone packaging. That alternative still has to explain the difference between conveying an attitude and presenting a sound.

A depictive sign conventionally presents a sound, event, or sensory scene through a resemblance between aspects of its performance and what it depicts. Dingemanse's account of ideophones supplies the wider comparison: conventional lexical items can depict sensory imagery, and their grammatical organization varies across languages (Dingemanse, 2018, pp. 2–3). The term expressive is itself used for ideophones in some traditions; that usage doesn't identify them with Potts's expressives.

For the selected *Bang!*, the relevant contribution is a portrayal of an impact sound. For *Damn!*, it's the conveyed stance toward a situation. The distinction changes the interpretation of a possible modification. In a constructed narrative, *bang, bang, bang* can multiply portrayed impacts; repeated *damn* can strengthen the conveyed stance. Repetition can thus transform the contribution in different ways. These examples articulate the contrast to be explained; they aren't results from a new elicitation study.

The literature motivates those different targets. Potts treats repetition as potentially strengthening expressive contribution (Potts, 2007, pp. 181–182). Dingemanse connects depictive performance with iconic mappings between form and scene (Dingemanse, 2018, pp. 10–11). An investigation can ask whether repetition changes portrayed event structure, conveyed stance, or both. It needn't assume one answer for every form traditionally called an interjection.

The descriptive comparison has a definite result. Separate expressive and depictive groupings preserve a difference in contribution that the undifferentiated alternative omits. A richer alternative could keep one superordinate class and record the difference as subtypes or dimensions. For this descriptive task, that's an acceptable equivalent if it retains the two relations. The result requires the distinction; it doesn't require a particular taxonomic rank.

Projective category standing remains a further question. Identifying a use as depictive from its interpretation under repetition and then predicting that interpretation from the label would recycle the admission evidence. An independent test could identify the use from unrepeated contexts and examine modifications elsewhere. Existing accounts motivate that comparison; the two illustrations don't establish a general response to repetition or a complete partition of semantic signs.

The groupings also needn't be disjoint. A depiction can convey an attitude, and an expressive performance can exploit resemblance. What matters is whether the relevant contribution is conventional

in the selected use and what follows from it. Semantics can investigate both relations, or several more, without assigning each to a separate department or requiring one category to represent the semantic perspective as a whole.

2.3 Contribution, encoding, and competing analyses

Consider the constructed utterance *The damn car won't start*, said after several failed attempts at ignition. The speaker reports a starting problem and conveys a negative attitude. Calling *damn* expressive identifies that second contribution. Asking how the wording helps a hearer recover the attitude raises a different question about its encoding.

Wharton (2016) develops a procedural account of expressive meaning, connecting guidance for interpretation with the showing of emotion. Applied to the car example, such an account would treat *damn* as a cue for recognizing the attitude being shown. The use could then be expressive in contribution and procedural in encoding. Those descriptions would answer different questions about the same utterance.

Now imagine a narrator representing the car's backfire with *Bang!*. The sign depicts a noise, and its performance can resemble what it depicts. That iconic presentation differs from *damn*'s conveyed stance. Identifying the depiction still leaves open how the sign guides interpretation: resemblance alone doesn't decide whether it supplies conceptual content, an interpretive procedure, or some combination.

Two accounts would compete if they made exclusive claims about the same *damn* use. Suppose one assigned it only conceptual content, such as a negative evaluation, while the other assigned it only a procedure for recognizing an attitude. These are hypothetical rivals, not summaries of Potts and Wharton. The first needn't make annoyance part of what the sentence asserts. Their incompatible claims about encoding would require adjudication.

Finer groupings also become visible in ordinary situations. Someone touches a hot pan and says *Ouch!*; someone finds missing keys under a newspaper and says *Aha!*. The situations are constructed; Ameka (1992, p. 113) gives the forms as examples of emotive and cognitive interjections. The first gives voice to a sensation, the second displays a change in knowledge or recognition.

Ameka's mental-state grouping is broader than the stance grouping used here. Finding the keys can be displayed with *Aha!* without conventionally evaluating them. That reading motivates a cognitive subtype; it doesn't prevent another occurrence from also conveying affect. Different contributions, crosscutting accounts of encoding, and rival encoding hypotheses thus have different consequences even within this small set of expressions.

2.4 Interactional resource classes

Consider two constructed exchanges. A teller says *I tried the front door*, a listener responds *Mm-hm*, and the teller continues *but it was locked*. The listener supports continuation of the story. In a second exchange, someone says *We meet at five*; a recipient who missed the time responds *Huh?*, and the first speaker repeats *At five*. Here the response prompts repair.

The difference concerns what happens next: the story proceeds after the continuer, while the meeting time is repeated after the repair initiator. Closing *bye* has another job, participating in the end of an encounter. Accounts of interjections in conversation make these sequential differences central (Dingemanse, 2024, pp. 257–259, 263–265). Their union doesn't supply one expectation about the next turn.

For comparison, these can be collected as conventional action formats: non-elliptical resources that can perform their action without a lexically specified host. The working class collects resources whose particular sequential consequences still need separate characterization. Such predictions belong initially to particular resource classes and environments. The contribution of a superordinate interactional category would need separate support.

The criterion has consequences at the boundary. Response *okay* and closing or thanking *thanks* are candidates insofar as their selected uses conventionally perform the relevant action. A formulaic greeting *how are you?* can qualify despite having several words. An ordinary imperative *stop!* doesn't qualify merely because clause structure permits it to stand alone; a claim that it's also a conventional routine needs evidence beyond that structure.

Host-dependent *please* in *please sit down* belongs to a different comparison. A standalone appeal *Please!* would have to be assessed as that selected use. Thus the admission rule concerns conventional action formats, rather than brevity, wordhood, or every expression capable of being uttered alone. These constructed comparisons specify the proposal; they don't supply an annotated inventory.

The grammatical treatment of *mm-hm* and *huh?* likewise needs more than standalone occurrence. Ameka (1992, p. 114) includes the former among phatic interjections; Wilkins (1992, p. 152) treats repair *huh?* as a conventional utterance. For the selected uses, I adopt the non-elliptical analysis: neither needs a recovered nominal head or clause to supply its interpretation. The grammatical assignments below are defeasible analyses supported by these descriptions, rather than deductions from punctuation.

Routine formulae expose competition within an inquiry. Ameka (1992, pp. 108–110) separates *bye*, *sorry*, and *thank you* from interjections, whereas Wilkins (1992, p. 142) treats routines as a subtype. Both attend to meaning and interaction. Assigning each a disciplinary label would misdescribe their disagreement. The selected closing format can be compared with continuers without settling whether the wider grouping is the most useful category for either question.

2.5 Common bearers and distinct questions

A sign-type is an identifiable expression in a conventional use. Its profile is the combination of grammatical, semantic, interactional, and other properties attributed to it. A use can retain its identity while a proposed property turns out to be absent. Otherwise every surprising observation would identify a different object and leave the original proposal immune to correction.

The recurrent contrast between standalone and prenominal *damn* supports distinguishing their conventional uses. In the complement-taking case, Table 1 classifies the lexical head *damn* in that construction. The whole phrase's external distribution is evidence about its environment, not a replacement bearer. The table records analytical judgments, not counts or results of a new annotation study.

Several analyses can assign the same selected uses for different reasons. The examples establish expressive commonality across a grammatical difference and different contributions within a semantic comparison. They leave the overall relation between the grammatical and interactional extensions open. Agreement over selected cases neither supplies an extensional separation nor settles how far the groupings coincide.

Bang! makes the unresolved grammatical question concrete. English also has nominal *bang*, as in the constructed *a loud bang* and *two bangs*. A standalone occurrence needs assessment against

Table 1: Selected conventional uses and the relations preserved by named analyses. The columns organize descriptions; they don't allocate one category to each field.

Selected bearer	Grammatical analysis	Meaning or action under comparison
gee!; stance *damn!*	Interjection	Expressive contribution; stance display
damn in *damn + NP*	Interjection head or verb: unresolved	Expressive contribution; the head's sequential affordances remain to be specified
Prenominal *damn*	Integrated modifier	Expressive contribution across a grammatical difference
Continuer *mm-hm*	Interjection analysis adopted	Continuation resource; no evaluative stance required by the selected reading
Repair *huh?*	Interjection analysis adopted	Open repair initiator; no evaluative stance required by the selected reading
Closing *bye*	Formulaic standalone expression	Closing resource
Depictive *Bang!*	Interjection or nominal-fragment analysis: unresolved	Sound depiction; stance is a separate question

a nominal-fragment analysis. Its depictive interpretation can be recognized while that question remains open. Section 4 completes the related assessment of what phonological evidence can decide.

3 What warrants a class, a category, or an explanation?

The expressive–depictive comparison establishes a descriptive distinction. Whether either grouping supports further induction is a different question. The same distinction applies to grammatical and interactional proposals: an inventory can organize the observed uses accurately while leaving its reach beyond those observations unknown. A common assessment should recognize both the value of that description and the additional commitment made when an empirical category is proposed.

3.1 Bearers, grouping, contribution, and alternatives

Four questions organize the assessment. What bears membership? What groups the members? What does the grouping help an investigator distinguish, infer, or explain? And what alternative would serve the same inquiry? Each proposal also needs a scope: a language or community, relevant conditions, and, where the claim concerns change, a period. These questions apply to established proposals and new candidates alike.

The bearer is the object grouped. Two recordings of *The damn car won't start* contain two realizations of the selected prenominal *damn* use. Counting the recordings gives two occurrences, not two sign-types. A phonologist can classify the individual productions; a lexical inquiry can ask about the conventional use they realize. A historian may instead classify a change connecting an earlier sign with a later one.

The grouping basis supplies the assignment evidence. Prenominal *damn* enters the expressive grouping because of its conveyed stance, while its position inside *the damn car* supplies grammatical

evidence. Grouping it with standalone *Damn!* for the first reason doesn't erase their difference in the second respect. Other proposals can use ancestry or participation in a social repertoire; each needs to identify the relation its membership records.

The CONTRIBUTION identifies what the grouping accomplishes. A constructed class can fix a comparison set. A descriptive class can organize a recurrent relation across independently identified cases. A category claim requires evidence that co-occurring properties support induction beyond the application conditions. A causal claim requires evidence about the process producing an outcome. These achievements can accumulate, but evidence for an earlier one doesn't establish a later one automatically.

Descriptive success can be assessed without requiring a prediction about a differently named property. The expressive grouping preserves a semantic relation across standalone and integrated constructions; the expressive–depictive contrast records different contributions concealed by the broad cover term. Those are warranted uses of descriptive classes. Calling them descriptions doesn't diminish their scientific value. It specifies the achievement so that categoryhood, in the stronger sense used here, remains an answerable further question.

An ALTERNATIVE can be a broader class, narrower subtypes, a continuous dimension, or an item-by-item account. In the worked semantic comparison, separate classes and a superordinate class with explicit subtypes both preserve the decisive distinction. For an inquiry into recipient responses, action-specific groupings may be more informative than their union. The number and rank of categories are outcomes of comparison, rather than requirements supplied by a field or inquiry.

Table 2: Assessing the expressive grouping without conflating its achievements

Question	Proposed answer	Evidential consequence
Bearer	Conventional uses, including standalone and prenominal *damn*	Identify each use without requiring the target property under investigation.
Grouping	Deployment conventionally conveys evaluative or affective stance	Distinguish this from describing an emotion, depicting a scene, or managing interaction.
Contribution	Preserve expressive commonality across grammatical constructions	Distinguish the observed contrast from its extension to new realizations, environments, or sign-types.
Alternative	An undifferentiated interjection class, explicit subtypes, or item-specific accounts	Compare which semantic relations each preserves and what further generalization each warrants.

3.2 From proposal to category claim

An admission rule fixes which cases enter a class. A category claim makes a further commitment: membership supports informative expectations beyond the evidence used to assign it. Assembling a grouping and warranting those expectations can succeed or fail separately. Here, category standing names the latter achievement; it isn't a verdict on whether a descriptive class is scientifically useful.

Three constructed comparisons distinguish the reach of an expectation. After identifying the expressive contribution in *The damn car won't start*, an investigator could examine another speaker's utterance of that sentence, the question *Has the damn car broken down?*, or *The bloody car won't start*. These comparisons change the realization, the environment, and the expression respectively.

The question supplies a concrete target: does the negative stance remain conveyed while the car's breakdown is put in question? Evidence from declaratives needn't settle that. The investigator can test the familiar property in a new environment without inventing a differently named property. Generalizing to independently identified *bloody* makes a further commitment across sign-types. Neither move is licensed simply by defining the class to contain the desired cases.

An additional shared property isn't sufficient merely because it's additional. If all members and nearly every sign outside a proposed grouping exhibit the target repetition behavior, membership supplies little additional guidance about it. An imperfect probabilistic association can be informative when it changes a warranted expectation at the stated scope. The alternatives in the preceding section help assess that contribution.

This comparison concerns what membership licenses an investigator to expect. Whether a category representation improves a particular model is a separate question, taken up below. Projective warrant doesn't require that representation to outperform every account of the same evidence. Both claims remain limited to the profile and scope tested: support for a subtype doesn't automatically extend to its superordinate class.

I provisionally accept the grammatical and action-specific categories used here for the relations documented in the cited descriptions. This inherits their evidential warrant at that scope; it doesn't establish every extension considered here. The present comparisons defend expressive and depictive distinctions and reject an unsupported transfer from phonology to grammar. They leave the broader projective standing of the proposed semantic, phonological, and ancestry groupings open.

3.3 Projection and identity

A projective claim states what's been observed, what's expected, and over which bearers and conditions. Its warrant is the evidence supporting that expectation (Goodman, 1955). A precise specification can have little warrant; a reliable association can remain causally unexplained. The content, evidential status, and proposed ground of a claim need separate assessment (Reynolds, 2026, pp. 11–12).

Suppose source contexts identify an expressive use and the target is its interpretation under repetition. Repetition can't also supply the case-level evidence used to admit that use. Similarly, if resistance to determiner combination is the target, an unexpected determiner can't by itself justify excluding the case as conversion. A change to the identification rule creates a revised claim requiring assessment.

Imagine an investigator who's identified expressive *damn* only in standalone reactions such as *Damn! We've missed the train*. Their provisional identification uses the reaction meaning; it doesn't require standalone position. They predict that these uses resist grammatical integration. Encountering *The damn car won't start* then presents an adverse case: the expression conveys stance while functioning as an integrated modifier inside the noun phrase.

This is a hypothetical research sequence using familiar constructions. The investigator should check the structural analysis, but the confirmed prenominal occurrence counts against the restriction under the original identification rule. Its inconvenient distribution isn't by itself a reason to remove it

from that assessment. Later recognizing a distinct prenominal use can improve the analysis without making the original prediction successful.

Evaluate the original projection under the identification rule available when it was made. Later evidence may warrant distinguishing a recurrent conventional use by its contribution or distribution. That revision can improve subsequent predictions, but it doesn't remove earlier counterexamples from the original assessment. Observations that motivate a new distinction don't also supply independent confirmation of its predictive success.

A quoted token or a productive noun denoting an utterance remains another possible analysis, but it needs evidence for quotation or nominal reference. A correction to a mistaken structural analysis should be recorded as such. It differs from changing the identification rule so that a confirmed counterexample no longer falls within its scope.

An informative restriction also needs relevant opportunities. Failure to observe inflection says little if the sampled environments wouldn't elicit it under a rival analysis. A grammatical test needs source and target constructions; an interactional test needs actions and sequential environments. The common bearer allows these claims to concern the same use. It doesn't make their evidence interchangeable.

3.4 Representation and causal explanation

Suppose an inventory records that a use occurs standalone and conveys stance. Adding the label "standalone stance use" abbreviates those two observations; it adds no information to a fully observed record. The combined grouping could still be useful when investigating something not yet recorded, such as interpretation under repetition. Pooling observations from its members might help estimate that pattern from sparse records. Whether it does is a comparative question.

The grouping selects an intersection: stance *Damn!* qualifies, while prenominal *damn* in *the damn car* fails the standalone condition. A model can represent that intersection as one label or keep its two component assignments. Their relative value depends on the information available and the target being predicted. A benefit for estimating repetition behavior wouldn't establish a unique cause of the shared properties or priority for every inquiry.

Explanation asks another question. Once the present form of *gee* has been recorded, knowing its religious source adds nothing to that already observed spelling. Its history can still explain how the form arose. More generally, conditioning a prediction on consequences of a historical process can remove the association through which that process is recognized. Section 5 distinguishes this predictive comparison from assessment of the proposed history itself.

Hill (1965, pp. 295–299) offered viewpoints for comparing causal interpretations with alternatives, including temporal order and consistency with independently supported knowledge. They concern specified causes and outcomes; they neither establish category standing nor form a mechanical checklist. Section 5 applies the temporal question to *gee*. Recurrence alone identifies neither a causal ordering nor a process that maintains a profile.

4 Phonological organization and situated realization

Phonological evidence already enters descriptions of interjections in two forms. Some signs permit sounds or combinations unusual elsewhere in a variety; particular occurrences also have distinctive prosodic packaging. These observations motivate different classifications. The first can group sign-types by their phonological possibilities. The second groups realizations by how speakers produce

them in context. Their relation is empirically interesting precisely because they don't classify the same objects.

4.1 A phonological stratum of signs

English conversational clicks make the first possibility concrete. The click represented by *tut-tut* differs from an ordinary spelling pronunciation (Wilkins, 1992, p. 147). Forms such as *ugh* permit sounds outside the usual phoneme inventory of standard British and American English (Quirk et al., 1985, p. 853). A phonological inquiry can ask which conventional signs admit such resources, how their variants are organized, and how speakers acquire or adapt them.

Ameka (1992, pp. 112–113) diagnoses a specific inference: unusual phonology shared with interjections has been used to include onomatopoeic words in the grammatical interjection category. His alternative is to recognize a phonological grouping whose members can belong to different grammatical categories. The following assessment develops the evidential consequence of that distinction.

The grammatical claim concerns membership in a lexical category. The evidence offered concerns sounds or sound patterns unusual elsewhere in the language. That evidence supports a comparison of phonological possibilities across independently identified signs. By itself, it doesn't settle whether a particular use has nominal, verbal, or interjectional grammar. Nor does sound depiction itself entail phonological anomaly: resemblance and distribution within the sound system are different relations.

Phonological evidence can support a grammatical expectation where an independently established association warrants it. The shared unusualness considered here doesn't itself establish that association. The limitation concerns the evidence connecting the properties, not the fact that they belong to different domains.

For English *Bang!*, the competing grammatical analysis is a standalone nominal fragment, supported as a possibility by the independently available noun in *a loud bang*. A depictive interpretation leaves that analysis open. Even if an occurrence had unusual phonation, the additional observation would concern its realization. Choosing between nominal and interjectional analyses needs distributional and constructional evidence about the selected conventional use, or an independently warranted association connecting the observed phonology to that grammar.

The strongest alternative retains one broad descriptive class and records phonology and grammar as separate attributes. For organizing known cases, that can preserve the same information. It becomes inadequate only if membership in the broad class is used to infer a grammatical assignment without the relevant evidence. The assessment rejects that inference while retaining the cross-grammatical phonological comparison. It doesn't establish a single projectible phonological stratum.

An account of the stratum would gain projective reach if membership organized acquisition, adaptation, or alternation beyond the diagnostic used to identify it. Consider the contrast between producing a click and pronouncing *tut-tut* as spelled words. An investigation could first group signs by independently recorded articulations, then ask which permit a spelling pronunciation and in what settings. That prospective comparison would test a relation beyond the articulation used for grouping; the reported alternatives don't yet establish it.

Regular phonology matters too. In a ten-language study of open repair interjections, Dingemanse et al. (2013) find broad phonetic similarities alongside language-specific vowel targets and intonation. The repair interjections in Icelandic and Cha'palaa have falling contours, consistent with local interrogative prosody. The study concerns comparable repair environments. It supplies no reason to assign every occurrence resembling *huh* to one phonologically exceptional class.

Phonological classification thus has work to do within ordinary linguistic organization as well as at its margins. An inquiry into repair intonation could group forms with interrogative resources; another into unusual segments could group conversational clicks with other marked forms. Both could be useful. A single label such as PHONOLOGICAL INTERJECTION would obscure the difference unless the inquiry and grouping basis were specified.

4.2 Prosodic classes of realizations

A prosodic boundary is a property of a realization. A sign-type can characteristically occupy its own intonation phrase while allowing different realizations in different environments. Conversely, realizations of grammatically different signs can share a boundary pattern. Supplements provide a familiar example: interjections, noun phrases, and relative clauses can all be prosodically detached (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 66, 1350).

Take a recording of *Damn, we're going to be late!*. The context can identify the reaction use while the acoustic record supplies evidence about a boundary, such as a pause or pitch movement. A second recording can realize the same use with different timing. Classifying these productions asks how that occurrence was packaged; a claim about characteristic packaging needs the distribution of productions across relevant environments.

Interaction supplies some of those environments. Ogden (2013) describes English clicks and percussives in stance-taking, sequence management, word searches, and turn timing, with visual behaviour contributing to their interpretation. A classification of productions by timing and articulation can intersect an analysis of sequential practices. The range of jobs also cautions against assigning one conventional action or expressive meaning to every click.

The comma in a transcript of *Damn, we're going to be late!* is a different kind of observation. It may record a transcriber's analysis of detachment, but it isn't itself a pause or a grammatical relation. Entering that comma once as a prosodic boundary and again as syntactic independence would manufacture apparent agreement between the measures. An acoustic analysis and a constructional analysis can converge without relying on that single transcription decision.

The two phonological inquiries extend the family in different ways. Phonological strata can share their sign-type bearers and enter membership intersections. Prosodic classes of occurrences connect to them through realization and through distributions over contexts. Treating both as extra columns in the same sign-type table would hide the relation that the phonological inquiry is meant to explain.

5 Historical ancestry and classes of change

A historical classification asks how signs came to have their present properties. Signs with different current distributions can descend from related sources, while signs with similar current profiles can arrive by different routes. The inquiry can classify present signs by independently established ancestry. It can also classify historical changes, such as clipping or reanalysis. The first has sign-types as bearers; the second has changes linking sources and outcomes.

5.1 The documented route to *gee*

Gehweiler (2008) traces *gee* through an invocation of *Jesus*, an exclamatory use of the religious name, and a clipped form. In the invocation, the speaker addresses the deity. The exclamation can express a reaction without that address. Clipping then produces a form whose relation to the name can become opaque. The sequence separates semantic change from the later change of form.

The transitions also have different proposed explanations. Gehweiler relates the first to gradual invited inference, aided by the syntactically peripheral invocation. She analyzes the clipping as an abrupt, taboo-motivated change involving hearer reanalysis (Gehweiler, 2008, pp. 84–88). The source invocation already permits peripheral packaging. Its development gives no reason to assume that a new prosodic boundary caused the semantic transition or that all the properties changed together.

The history explains why the shape of *gee* bears a relation to religious invocation even for a speaker who doesn't recognize that relation. Its present opacity alone wouldn't identify its ancestry. The documented sequence supplies the additional evidence for a restricted instance of path dependence: a particular route helps explain a feature of its outcome, without making every other outcome of that route predictable.

The explanation concerns a particular outcome. It doesn't yet establish that a class of signs with religious ancestry outperforms alternatives or supports a common projection. That comparison would require independently documented histories and outcomes across more than this one route.

Hill's considerations clarify a tempting stronger claim. If newly acquired prosodic isolation were proposed as a cause of the semantic change, the already peripheral invocation would fail to supply the required change in exposure. The cited history doesn't independently measure a prosodic innovation preceding the semantic transition. Plausibility of a prosody–syntax connection can't supply that missing temporal comparison. An already present peripheral construction could still be an enabling condition for later change. Gehweiler's proposed roles for invited inference and taboo-motivated clipping remain distinct historical claims with their own evidence.

The distinction also corrects an ambiguity in PRIMARY and SECONDARY interjections. Ameka's distinction concerns whether a form has other, non-interjectional uses in the language (Ameka, 1992, pp. 105–106). It isn't a partition into historically underived and historically derived signs. Gehweiler's primary *gee* has a documented derived history. Conversely, an unknown etymology supplies a gap in knowledge, not a common origin shared by all forms whose sources remain unknown.

5.2 Source, mechanism, transmission, and trajectory

A useful historical description separates four relations. The SOURCE identifies an earlier sign or construction. The MECHANISM specifies a change, such as clipping or reanalysis. The TRANSMISSION SETTING concerns how the innovation spreads, including borrowing where supported. The subsequent TRAJECTORY concerns further changes in use or form. Signs can share one relation without sharing the other three.

For *gee*, a religious invocation supplies the source and tabooistic clipping supplies one mechanism. Those facts don't establish the transmission history of every later community's use. Nor does a shared source force a common trajectory: an exclamatory religious name can remain phonologically close to its source without later undergoing clipping. Historical classes can be organized at several levels, according to which relation the inquiry needs.

The proposed verbal route to complement-taking *damn* illustrates unequal support among histories. *God damn him* has the shape of an optative, a construction independently recognized in English (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 944). Omission of the subject and increasing conventional expressive force offer a plausible route to *damn him*. The surviving complement fits that reconstruction. These synchronic comparisons don't establish the sequence as independently as Gehweiler's historical record does.

The source optative already uses plain-form *damn*, so the reconstruction doesn't require loss of

tense marking at that transition. And the present complement remains compatible with competing analyses of the head as verbal or interjectional. A classification by independently established verbal ancestry could cross that present grammatical boundary. Inferring the ancestry solely from the complement and then invoking the ancestry to predict that same complement would be circular.

Classes of changes require a different representation. An instance of clipping relates an earlier form to an outcome; an instance of semantic reanalysis relates earlier and later interpretations. Neither is itself a sign-type alongside *gee* and *damn*. A process classification can support comparisons among developments, while explicit source–result relations connect those developments to classifications of their inputs and outputs.

5.3 What historical evidence can establish

Historical explanation and forward projection need different comparisons. A documented route may explain a present feature through the changes that produced it. A forward projection asks what information about the route warrants expecting in another case. For a verbal-source class, that target could concern surviving restrictions on dependents, provided those restrictions weren't used to assign the source. The present examples motivate that inquiry without establishing a category-wide result.

Evidence for replication also needs to distinguish innovations from their descendants. Suppose one community coins a clipped exclamation and three others borrow it. Four community records then document one origin, not four independent instances of clipping. They can support an account of transmission or subsequent divergence. Testing whether the same source repeatedly gives rise to the same outcome would require independently established innovations. This hypothetical count makes the sampling unit depend on the historical claim.

An ancestry classification can still explain a present contrast even when ancestry adds no predictive information after all its consequences are observed. Conditioning on those consequences changes the question to whether ancestry contributes anything further. That can be a useful test of predictive economy; it isn't a general test of whether the documented process occurred or helped produce the contrast.

Historical classes can have two kinds of payoff. They can organize independently supported source relations among present signs, and they can compare processes across developments. These are legitimate descriptive and explanatory contributions. An empirical ancestry category, in the stronger usage adopted here, also needs support for the inductions it licenses. The documented history of one sign can't supply that support for an entire source class.

6 Broader classes and further inquiries

The traditional interjection domain also intersects classes whose most informative members lie elsewhere. Social regulation can group forms by their appropriateness for audiences and settings. Processing inquiries can group familiar expressions by how they're produced or understood. An interjection's membership in either class needn't make the class interjection-specific. Three questions remain distinct: whether the broader class is supported, how it intersects the traditional domain, and whether an INTERJECTION label helps describe that intersection.

6.1 Social regulation and socially recognized repertoires

Religious exclamations make social regulation relevant to the worked case. In Gehweiler's account, taboo pressure contributes to clipping *Jesus* into *gee*. A present-day inquiry might instead group uses according to their evaluated appropriateness for an audience or setting. The historical cause of an innovation and the current regulation of its descendants are separate targets; evidence for one doesn't settle the other.

Jay and Janschewitz (2008) examine ratings of hypothetical swearing scenarios, finding that judgments depend on the word, speaker–listener relations, and social and physical context. Such evidence supports contextual differentiation in evaluations of taboo language. It doesn't directly observe sanctions or show that corrective responses maintain a class of interjections. Those stronger proposals would need their own measures of behaviour and change.

Consider a proposed comparison of *Gee!* and *Jesus!* as reactions to surprising news among close friends and during a formal interview. Ratings would ask how appropriate each choice seems in each setting. A listener actually correcting a speaker's choice would be a different observation. Repeated corrections followed by changes in use would be relevant to a further claim about regulation. The comparison specifies possible evidence, not findings about these forms.

Social indexing poses a related but distinct inquiry. Agha's account of enregisterment concerns the social recognition of speech forms as indexing attributes of speakers, with a repertoire's associations and social reach subject to change (Agha, 2005, pp. 38–40). A classification by participation in a recognized repertoire could cross grammatical, semantic, and sequential divisions. The relevant evidence concerns recognition and use of those associations, beyond a frequency difference between geographical collections.

For example, if listeners regularly associated *Gee!* with an old-fashioned speaker persona, their judgments would support a social association. They wouldn't merely be rating whether it was acceptable in the interview. Both investigations could concern the same surprise reaction, while asking different questions about its social meaning. Such associations could also unite forms used for several actions. Any claimed convention would need a specified community and evidence of shared recognition.

6.2 Formulaicity and processing

Compare a familiar greeting, *How are you?*, a pause filler, *um*, and the idiom *kick the bucket*. These illustrative forms differ in grammar and conversational job. A processing inquiry could ask whether speakers produce them as familiar routines. Its grouping would cross the earlier grammatical and semantic divisions; formulaic expressions might name it more clearly than another kind of interjection.

Van Lancker Sidtis et al. (2015) report differences in formulaic language production and comprehension across clinical groups and healthy participants. Their production analysis combines six kinds of formulaic material, including conversational formulae, pause fillers, sentence stems, and idioms. The results give empirical consequences to that broader organization. They don't isolate an interjection-specific processing class or locate a neural basis for grammatical interjections, expressive signs, or particular interactional resources.

For the greeting, one question is whether *How are you?* is retrieved fluently because repeated use has helped establish a routine. A comparison at the same measured frequency asks how fluency differs among expressions with comparable recorded use. That adjustment doesn't by itself identify how

much repetition contributed to the greeting's fluency. A causal interpretation still needs assumptions about exposure, retrieval, and how the frequency measure relates to speakers' experience.

Suppose retrieval across *How are you?*, *um*, and *kick the bucket* tracked familiarity more closely than any interjection grouping. That result would favour the broader or continuous representation for this processing inquiry. It wouldn't give the filler *um* the internal grammar of *kick the bucket*. The grammatical contrast would remain available for a different question, provided its own evidence held.

6.3 Keeping the family open without multiplying labels

Other inquiries are easy to motivate, but motivation alone doesn't establish their proposed categories. Table 3 identifies several candidates and the contribution each would need to specify. The table is an agenda for distinguishing questions. It makes no claim that every row identifies a single class, that their extensions are independent, or that all deserve an interjection label.

Table 3: Further inquiries illustrated by constructed comparisons

Inquiry	Possible bearer	Concrete question to assess
Morphological organization	Sign-types in identified constructions	Does exclamatory *heavens!* participate in a productive number contrast?
Semiotic relations	Conventional signs, or sign–referent relations	How do stance *Damn!* and depictive *Bang!* relate form to interpretation?
Development and learning	Learners' repertoires or acquisition episodes	What changes between a child's first and later uses of *ouch*?
Multimodal organization	Conventional complexes or situated performances	How does *Bye!* coordinate with a wave, and what does each component contribute?
Graphic communication	Written sign-types or particular inscriptions	What does *BANG* in a comic panel represent, compared with *bang* in a transcript?
Annotation	Tokens under a stated coding scheme	Should a query return both *Ha! I knew it* and *12 ha of land*?

Morphology illustrates the distinctions within a row. The absence of an inflectional paradigm differs from resistance to derivation. A retained plural shape in exclamatory *heavens!* differs from a productive number contrast. Attested noun and verb uses of *ouch* in child-directed speech show why a claim about invariance needs to specify the conventional use (Stange, 2016, p. 36). These facts motivate several comparisons, without supplying one morphological definition of interjectionhood.

In a constructed comic panel, *BANG* beside a backfiring car can depict its noise without representing anyone's speech. In a transcript, *bang* can instead record a narrator's spoken depiction. The inscriptions have the same letters but stand in different relations to speech and events. Work on ideophones distinguishes depiction from the predominantly indexical relation associated with interjections (Dingemanse, 2018; Dingemanse & Akita, 2017); identifying the relation in a particular inscription needs evidence about its use.

Following a child learning *ouch* would record a learner, occasions of use, and changes between them. Those episodes aren't additional entries in an adult inventory. Likewise, a recording of *Bye!*

with a wave includes the timing of a visible movement, which the lexical sign alone doesn't specify. Acquisition and performance can be classified, but their connection to sign-types runs through learning and realization rather than shared membership in one list.

Annotation makes the practical stakes clear. A tag can be useful for retrieving conversational responses even if its extension combines several grammatical or semantic classes. Its success is then measured against the retrieval task and coding policy. That success doesn't establish a lexical category. Conversely, poor retrieval under a particular tag says little about the existence of a distinction the tagging scheme wasn't designed to record.

7 A measurement case: tags, strings, and uses

A corpus query can identify a useful class without recovering the intended linguistic bearers. The Corpus of Global Web-Based English (GloWbE) contains country-labelled web sections (Davies & Fuchs, 2015). An interjection tag, the string *ha*, and a conventional interjectional use of *ha* select different sets. Confusing them can turn a retrieval convention into apparent evidence about a category.

The constructed strings *12 ha of land* and *Ha! I knew it* make the difference visible. A search for the spelling *ha*, ignoring capitalization, can retrieve both. An investigation of the reaction use needs to distinguish them. A tag intended to make that distinction is still a measurement decision whose accuracy needs checking.

The *ha* record makes the consequence concrete. Some tagged occurrences abbreviate HECTARE, especially in agricultural prose. A rule-based screen of exported contexts changes Kenya's rank from fifth to fifteenth or sixteenth under six treatments of laughter and unclear cases; pooling gives ranks from fourteenth to sixteenth. The large movement is stable across those choices. Its exact size remains conditional on the screen and on the exported samples.

The screen was tuned against forty Kenyan and Tanzanian examples; its resulting 39/40 binary agreement is a development check. It doesn't establish equivalent accuracy in every country section. The observed geographic distribution depends on both the linguistic phenomenon and the measurement procedure. An analysis of category variation would need independently identified uses and comparable opportunities for their occurrence.

Similarly, changing frequency ranks in the Corpus of Historical American English (COHA) describe a tagged inventory (Davies, 2010). They don't establish persistence of a semantic or grammatical profile. Two further analyses, of derivatives and *fie*, fail their intended confirmatory interpretation: the primary derivative pipeline assigned semantic residue rather than measuring it, and the *fie* input retained ineligible optical character recognition substitutions. Their confirmatory claims are withdrawn.

The evidence supplement preserves the complete records: GloWbE measurement and model comparisons (Section A), the derivative audit (Section B), the *fie* audit (Section C), and inventory turnover (Section D). Its retained model comparison predicts an omitted country–item cell within the observed design; it doesn't assess new countries, new items, or the proposed linguistic groupings. These records locate the failure at the relevant claim. A useful retrieval class survives as a tool, but its output can't establish a linguistic category without evidence connecting that class to independently identified uses.

8 The general consequence

Named groupings expose what a broad interjection judgment can obscure. The grammatical analysis of prenominal *damn* concerns its integration into the noun phrase; the expressive analysis concerns its contribution to interpretation. Depictive *Bang!* poses another semantic question. Continuers and repair initiators organize different sequential environments. These relations needn't fit a fixed matrix with one column for each discipline.

8.1 Many-to-many relations and local failure

Dupré's pluralism and Khalidi's crosscutting kinds make room for multiple defensible groupings. The linguistic cases add a practical requirement: specify which relation a proposed grouping preserves and which objects participate in it. Haspelmath's division between descriptive categories and comparative concepts supplies a related lesson about analytical purpose. Here, the same care is needed within a language and within an inquiry.

In *The damn car won't start*, expressive contribution concerns the attitude conveyed; procedural encoding concerns how the wording guides its recognition. Both descriptions could hold. The contrast with depictive *Bang!* concerns a different contribution, while the exclusive encoding hypotheses in Section 2.3 disagree about the same use. Assigning the hypotheses to different fields wouldn't make their claims compatible.

Failure has correspondingly local consequences. Suppose a repetition test found that an independently identified expressive use didn't strengthen stance under the specified conditions. The prediction of intensification would fail there; the observed distinction between conveying stance and depicting a sound wouldn't disappear with it. Restricting the prediction to another subtype would create a new claim. Its support couldn't be inherited from the failed generalization.

This discipline also limits positive conclusions. The semantic comparison favours preserving expressive and depictive contributions, while leaving open whether separate classes, subtypes, or dimensions best serve a further task. The phonological comparison rejects an unsupported transfer to grammatical membership. The *gee* history supports a particular explanation. These are substantive outcomes without a claim that this paper has validated a complete family of empirical categories.

8.2 Overlap, mechanisms, and category standing

Selecting standalone stance uses includes expressive *Damn!* and excludes prenominal *damn* in *the damn car*. That intersection is well-defined and can fix a useful comparison set. Its further value depends on the question: does restricting attention to those uses help with the proposed inference? Neither the overlap itself nor the availability of its component assignments answers that.

Distinct categories needn't be statistically independent, and they can share causal processes. Strong correlation doesn't make two questions identical; a shared history doesn't establish every present property. A causal network is one possible account, provided its variables and links have independent support. Hill's considerations help assess specified causal interpretations; they don't turn covariation into a mechanism by being applied to a diagram.

For *Bang!*, uncertainty between a nominal-fragment and an interjection analysis doesn't itself establish graded membership. The analysis may simply be unresolved. A separate inquiry could ask how typical speakers judge it compared with *Damn!*; prototype accounts organize such typicality and similarity (Rosch, 1975; Taylor, 2003). Either a graded or a categorical representation can serve a task, but its form alone doesn't establish what it licenses an investigator to infer.

A field supplies no fixed quota of categories, and an inquiry needn't end with just one. A grouping may serve several questions across fields, but warrant only specified projections under specified conditions. The historical label INTERJECTION identifies a meeting point for these inquiries. The evidence, rather than the label or departmental boundary, determines which proposed categories deserve recognition.

9 Conclusion

English interjections expose a general difference between assembling a class and establishing an empirical category. Descriptive classes can make contrasts visible; category claims require co-occurring properties that support induction for particular purposes. Explanations require further evidence about how an outcome arose or is maintained. These achievements should be assessed for named groupings, not allocated in advance to grammar, semantics, and pragmatics.

The contrast between stance *Damn!* and depictive *Bang!* shows why one semantic inquiry can need several groupings. Unusual phonation in *Bang!* wouldn't by itself decide its grammar. The documented route to *gee* explains an outcome without validating an ancestry category. A query for *ha* can aid retrieval while also returning hectares. In each case, making the bearer, grouping basis, and intended contribution explicit changes what would count as support or counterevidence. An undifferentiated category judgment conceals those differences; the account developed here makes them available for adjudication.

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